Do They Think Alike?
Immigrant First-Generation Students' Decisions and Parents' Preferences for College Major and Career

Julie Vang, McNair Scholar, Catherine Solheim, Ph.D., and Veronica Deenanath, M.A.
Department of Family Social Science, University of Minnesota Twin Cities

INTRODUCTION

- **Immigrant first-generation college students** are individuals whose parents do not have a college degree and family recently migrated to the United States.[1]
- These students face challenges in college due to limited English, math, and study skills.[2]
- Students' decisions about school are collective endeavors influenced by their parents.[3]
- Students experience stress and pressure from familial obligations to succeed academically and contribute financially.[4]
- Little information is known about immigrant first-generation college students and the role their parents play in their major, career aspirations, and their perception of family support.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

1) Are immigrant first-generation college students' goals and ideas about major and career choice similar to their parents'?
2) How do students and parents perceive family support in regard to students' major and career decision-making?

METHODS

- Secondary data collected from May 2012 - November 2012 as part of a master's thesis research project.
- 30-60 minute semi-structured interviews were transcribed verbatim.
- Used thematic analysis[5] to analyze interview data to identify themes.
- Sample: 3 student-parent dyads

Students	Jia	Mai	Pa
Age	Missing	19	21
Generation	1.5	2nd	2nd
Location of Birth	Taiwan	Thailand	U.S.
Marital Status	Single	Single	Married
Children	0	0	2
Family's Annual Income	$30,000 - $75,000	$16,000 - $30,000	$16,000 - $30,000
Parents	**Jia's Mother**	**Mai's Mother**	**Pa's Mother**
Age	51	47	43
Years in the U.S.	5-9	10+	10+
Children	2	6	8
Location of Birth	Taiwan	Laos	Laos

**Students names have been changed to protect confidentiality*

**1.5 generation- Migrated to the U.S. between age 12-17 / 2nd generation- U.S. born who have a least one immigrant parent*

RESULTS

Four Primary Themes Found

Students' desire to work with people in their chosen career

All three students wanted to pursue a major that allowed them to express their passion for working with people.

Pa entered college as a pre-nursing major, but found the coursework was difficult. She eventually found a major that better fit her interest: child psychology.

Parents' desire for career choices that provided status and financial security

Parents felt that a college degree provided status; people are seen as worthy and prestigious.

With finances that were scarce, parents wanted their children to attain high-paying jobs and long-term financial stability.

Parents' desire for their children to maintain cultural roots

Parents recognized the importance of keeping their root culture, heritage, and language alive.

Mai's mother explained that her daughter must maintain their mother tongue. She also expressed her concern that her children's generation is less capable of doing basic traditional skills such as cooking or chopping meat.

Students' and parents' understanding of family support

Family support for students' success came in two forms:

Tangible
giving money, providing food, or preparing lunch.

Intangible
giving advice, encouragement, or motivation.

Jia's mother prepared meals for her daughter every day to show her support.

"I went through a lot of majors previously before I chose child psychology. I knew for a fact that I wanted to work with children and um maybe go somewhere in the medical field or like helping people um, and um, I have to go through a lot of help since I was getting close to my graduation year."
- Pa

"We can't let go of our language because it is important…The more you speak their language, the more you will lose your language…You Hmong Americans, I think are smart but are also really ignorant. You are smart in academics but handling household chores (including cooking), you don't know any."
- Mai's Mother

"People respect the rich people and people look at the poor people as the dirt that people step all over. So I tell them that you have to work hard on your education so others look at you with respect."
- Mai's Mother

"The parents need to do everything for the kids…it's different in America maybe "oh you already grow up, you need to do everything by yourself." But right now I need to prepare lunch box for her everyday."
- Jia's Mother

DISCUSSION & IMPLICATIONS

Discussion:

- Students' and parents' goals and ideas about major and career choices do not align. This is not a tug-of-war situation, but more of a give-and-take negotiation.
- Students respect their parents' desire when selecting a major and career.
- Parents have their own expectations for their children. Ultimately, happiness, financial stability, and preservation of cultural roots are more important.
- Families vary in the types of support they provide for their students depending on the situation.

Implications:

- This study provides 3 cases illustrating the highly varied and complex experiences of both immigrant first-generation college students and their parents.
- Higher education student affairs administrators should create programs that encourage parental and community engagement in their students' college experience.
- High school and postsecondary institutions should offer programs that introduce families and communities to the wide range of career possibilities.

LIMITATIONS

- Used secondary data which limited scope.
- Study conducted a small, all-female, public university sample which limited generalizability.

FUTURE RESEARCH

- Ask additional interview question:
  "What motivates the student to attend a 4-year university?"
- Incorporate longitudinal design to study students from high school to their collegiate experiences.
- Interview siblings to understand their impact on academic major, career choices, and family support.

REFERENCES:
1) Portes, A., Rumbaut, R.G. (2001). *Legacies: The story of the immigrant second generation.* University of California Press, Berkeley, CA. / **2)** Soria, K. M., & Stebleton, M. J. (2013). Immigrant college students' academic obstacles. *The Learning Assistance Review, 18*(1), 7-24. / **3)** McCarron, G. P., & Inkelas, K. K. (2006). The gap between educational aspirations and attainment for first-generation college students and the role of parental involvement. *Journal of College Student Development, 47*(5), 534-549. / **4)** Kim, E. (2009). Navigating college life: The role of peer networks in first-year college adaptation experience of minority immigrant students. *Journal of the First-Year Experience & Students in Transition, 21*(2), 9-34. / **5)** Daly, K. J. (2007). *Qualitative methods for family studies and human development.* Sage Publications.

**Photo icons used from piktochart.com*